

EASY-READ EDITION

# Perfumery Compliance: A Practical Guide for Independent Perfumers

A plain-English read-through of IFRA calculations, allergens, supplier documents and the basics of selling perfume in the UK, EU and US.

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Written September 2026 · IFRA Standards in force: 51st Amendment (52nd Amendment expected to be notified late 2026)

Educational material only. Not legal, regulatory or toxicological advice.

#### DISCLAIMER

**This guide is for educational purposes only and is not legal, regulatory or toxicological advice. Regulations and IFRA Standards change over time. Always verify requirements against current official guidance, supplier documentation, and where appropriate a qualified cosmetic safety assessor.**

This guide covers the UK, EU and US. **Laws differ between countries and regions — do your own research into the rules for your country, your local area, and every market you sell or ship to.**

## Before You Start

This guide explains fragrance compliance in plain English. You don't need any regulatory knowledge to follow it, just a basic understanding of how perfume is made.

### Three things to know first:

1. **Compliance is manageable.** Most of it comes down to keeping good records and doing some simple maths.
2. **The numbers in the examples are made up.** Any IFRA limit used in an example is marked **HYPOTHETICAL**. It's there to teach the maths. Never copy it into a real formula. Always look up real limits in the official [IFRA Standards Library](#).
3. **Rules change.** This guide was written in **September 2026**. At that time the **51st Amendment** of the IFRA Standards was in force, and IFRA expected to publish the **52nd Amendment** around **late November 2026**. Always check for newer versions.

#### IMPORTANT

#### outside the UK, EU or US?

The IFRA maths in this guide works everywhere, but the **laws** covered here are only for Great Britain, the European Union and the United States. Countries such as Canada, Australia, Japan, China, the Gulf states and many others have their own rules, and there may also be state, provincial or local rules. If you ship abroad, the destination country's rules usually apply too. Start with your national cosmetics regulator and, before selling, check with a qualified local adviser.

## 1. What "Compliance" Actually Means

"Compliance" isn't one thing. It's several separate checks, and a perfume can pass one and fail another.

| Check                                | What it's about                                                                                               |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>IFRA compliance</b>               | Are the fragrance ingredients used below the fragrance industry's safety limits?                              |
| <b>Safety assessment (CPSR)</b>      | Has a qualified person confirmed the finished product is safe? ( <i>Legally required in the UK and EU.</i> )  |
| <b>Product file (PIF)</b>            | Is all the product's paperwork kept in one place, ready for an inspector?                                     |
| <b>Notification</b>                  | Has the product been registered with the authorities before sale?                                             |
| <b>Labelling</b>                     | Does the label show everything the law requires, including allergens?                                         |
| <b>Good manufacturing (GMP)</b>      | Was it made in a clean, controlled and traceable way?                                                         |
| <b>Chemical &amp; shipping rules</b> | Are raw materials and concentrates labelled for hazards, and is perfume shipped safely as a flammable liquid? |

## Why "IFRA compliant" does NOT mean "legal to sell"

An IFRA certificate only tells you that the **fragrance oil** is within IFRA's limits when used at a certain level. It says nothing about safety assessment, labels, notification or manufacturing. **IFRA is one piece of the puzzle, not the whole puzzle.**

## Who is responsible for what?

- **If you only create fragrance concentrates**, you're working with a chemical mixture. You need good records, IFRA calculations and your raw material safety sheets.
- **If you sell concentrate to another business**, you must also give them proper documents: a hazard label and Safety Data Sheet where required, an IFRA certificate and an allergen declaration.
- **If you sell a finished perfume to the public**, you are placing a **cosmetic** on the market. You need a Responsible Person, a safety assessment, a product file, notification and a legal label.

## 2. What Is IFRA?

The **International Fragrance Association (IFRA)** is the fragrance industry's global body. It publishes the **IFRA Standards**: safety rules that **ban, limit** or **set purity requirements** for certain fragrance ingredients.

The Standards are **industry self-regulation**, not law in themselves. However, suppliers, safety assessors and customers expect them almost everywhere.

**IFRA updates the Standards in batches called "Amendments."** Limits can go down, go up or disappear, and new materials can be added. That's why you should always check that supplier documents refer to the **current** Amendment.

## The four types of material

| Type             | Meaning                                                       |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Prohibited       | Must not be used.                                             |
| Restricted       | Can be used, but only up to a maximum level.                  |
| Specification    | Can be used only if it meets a purity or quality requirement. |
| No IFRA Standard | IFRA hasn't set a rule.                                       |

### IMPORTANT

"No IFRA Standard" does **not** mean "use as much as you like." The law, your safety assessor or hazard data may still limit it. For example, some materials are banned by EU cosmetics law for reasons unrelated to IFRA.

## 3. IFRA Categories

Different products put different amounts of fragrance on your skin. A perfume sprayed on the neck is very different from a candle or a shower gel. IFRA sorts products into **12 main categories**, and **each one has its own limits**.

| Category                  | Examples                                                      |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>4 — Fine fragrance</b> | Eau de Parfum, Eau de Toilette, Parfum, Cologne, perfume oils |
| 5A                        | Body lotion                                                   |
| 9                         | Soap, shower gel                                              |
| 12                        | Candles, reed diffusers                                       |

Most independent perfumers work in **Category 4**. The same fragrance oil can have a **different maximum** in a perfume, a lotion, a soap and a candle.

### IMPORTANT

Products such as body mists, hair mists and aftershaves may not be Category 4. Check your exact product type in IFRA's official category guidance, available from the [IFRA Standards documentation page](#).

## 4. How to Do IFRA Calculations

This is the most important skill in this guide. Take it one step at a time.

## The three percentages

| Percentage                                                                                             | Example |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|
| <b>1. Material in the concentrate:</b> how much of your fragrance oil is this material?                | 2%      |
| <b>2. Concentrate in the finished perfume (the "dosage"):</b> how much of the bottle is fragrance oil? | 20%     |
| <b>3. Material in the finished perfume:</b> how much of the bottle is this material?                   | 0.4%    |

**IFRA limits always refer to number 3, the finished product.**

## The main formula

Material % in finished perfume = (material % in concentrate × dosage %) ÷ 100

### EXAMPLE 1

A material is **2%** of the concentrate. The perfume is **20%** concentrate.

$(2 \times 20) \div 100 = 40 \div 100 = \mathbf{0.4\%}$  of the finished perfume.

*Check in grams:* 100 g of perfume contains 20 g of concentrate. 2% of 20 g = 0.4 g, and 0.4 g in 100 g = 0.4%. ✓

### EXAMPLE 2

A material is **5%** of the concentrate. The perfume is **25%** concentrate.

$(5 \times 25) \div 100 = 125 \div 100 = \mathbf{1.25\%}$  of the finished perfume.

This **1.25%** is the number you compare with the IFRA limit, not the 5%.

## Working backwards: how much can I use?

Maximum % in concentrate = (IFRA limit × 100) ÷ dosage %

### EXAMPLE 3

#### (HYPOTHETICAL limit)

A material has a Category 4 limit of **0.60%** (*hypothetical*). How much can go in the concentrate?

| Perfume dosage | Calculation                 | Maximum in concentrate |
|----------------|-----------------------------|------------------------|
| 10%            | $(0.60 \times 100) \div 10$ | <b>6.0%</b>            |
| 15%            | $(0.60 \times 100) \div 15$ | <b>4.0%</b>            |
| 20%            | $(0.60 \times 100) \div 20$ | <b>3.0%</b>            |
| 25%            | $(0.60 \times 100) \div 25$ | <b>2.4%</b>            |
| 30%            | $(0.60 \times 100) \div 30$ | <b>2.0%</b>            |

**The stronger the perfume, the less of a restricted material you can use in the concentrate.**

## Maximum dosage and the "limiting material"

This tells you the strongest you can make your perfume:

$$\text{Maximum dosage \%} = (\text{IFRA limit} \div \text{material \% in concentrate}) \times 100$$

Work this out for **every** restricted material. The **lowest** answer is your maximum, and the material that gives it is called the **limiting material**.

### EXAMPLE 4

#### (ALL LIMITS HYPOTHETICAL)

| Material | % in concentrate | Cat 4 limit | Calculation                  | Max dosage          |
|----------|------------------|-------------|------------------------------|---------------------|
| A        | 3.0%             | 0.60%       | $(0.60 \div 3.0) \times 100$ | 20%                 |
| B        | 0.5%             | 0.05%       | $(0.05 \div 0.5) \times 100$ | <b>10% ← lowest</b> |
| C        | 2.0%             | 2.50%       | $(2.50 \div 2.0) \times 100$ | 125% (never limits) |

**Material B is the limiting material.** This concentrate can be used at no more than **10%** in a fine fragrance.

### IMPORTANT

The maximum is a **ceiling, not a target**. Leave a safety margin for weighing errors and natural variation between batches.

## Diluted materials

If you use a material as a dilution, only the **active** part counts:

Active % = formula % × (dilution % ÷ 100)

#### EXAMPLE 5

Your formula contains **5%** of a **10% dilution** in DPG.

$5 \times (10 \div 100) = 5 \times 0.10 = \mathbf{0.5\%}$  actual material. Use **0.5%** in your IFRA maths, not 5%.

## Natural materials

Essential oils and absolutes are mixtures of many chemicals, and some of those chemicals are restricted. For example, lemongrass contains **citral** and clove contains **eugenol**. You must add up the restricted chemical from **every** source in your formula.

#### EXAMPLE 6

##### (HYPOTHETICAL numbers)

Your concentrate is **8%** essential oil. The **supplier's documents** say the oil contains **1.5%** of restricted "Constituent K."

$8 \times (1.5 \div 100) = \mathbf{0.12\%}$  Constituent K in the concentrate.

If you also add 0.03% of pure Constituent K elsewhere, the total is  $0.12 + 0.03 = \mathbf{0.15\%}$ . Use this total for your IFRA calculation.

The constituent percentages must come from **your supplier's documents** for the exact oil you bought, not from a website or a different supplier.

## Weigh, don't measure by volume

IFRA percentages are **by weight**. Alcohol is lighter than most fragrance oils, so mixing "20 ml oil + 80 ml alcohol" gives about **23% by weight**, not 20%. **Always weigh on a scale.**

## 5. Fragrance Allergens

Allergens and IFRA limits are **two different systems**:

- **IFRA limits** set the **maximum** amount of a material you can use.
- **Allergen labelling** is a **legal** rule that says certain materials must be **named on the label** if they're present above a small amount.

A material can be far below any IFRA limit and still need to go on the label.

### When to label (UK and EU)

A listed allergen must appear in the ingredient list if the finished product contains more than:

- **0.001%** in **leave-on** products (perfume, lotion);
- **0.01%** in **rinse-off** products (shower gel, shampoo).

## Which allergens?

- **EU:** the list was expanded to around 80 allergens by Regulation (EU) 2023/1545. New products placed on the market from **31 July 2026** must follow it, and older products can stay on sale until **31 July 2028**.
- **Great Britain:** at the time of writing, it still uses the **original, shorter list**. Check current UK government (OPSS) guidance.

### EXAMPLE 7

#### Linalool in an Eau de Parfum

Your concentrate contains **3%** linalool, plus **10%** lavender oil that is **30%** linalool (per the supplier).

Linalool from lavender:  $10 \times (30 \div 100) = \mathbf{3\%}$

Total linalool in the concentrate:  $3 + 3 = \mathbf{6\%}$

In the EDP at 18%:  $(6 \times 18) \div 100 = \mathbf{1.08\%}$

1.08% is far above 0.001%, so **"Linalool" must be on the label.**

## 6. Supplier Documents Explained

Ask your supplier for these for **every** raw material:

| Document                             | What it tells you                                                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>SDS</b> (Safety Data Sheet)       | Hazards, safe handling, storage, flash point and shipping info. <b>It is not proof of IFRA or cosmetic compliance.</b> |
| <b>IFRA Certificate</b>              | The maximum use level in each IFRA category. Check that it refers to the <b>current Amendment</b> .                    |
| <b>Allergen Declaration</b>          | Which allergens the material contains, and how much.                                                                   |
| <b>Specification / TDS</b>           | What the material should be: appearance, purity, density and so on.                                                    |
| <b>COA</b> (Certificate of Analysis) | Test results for the <b>exact batch</b> you received.                                                                  |

Keep them organised by **supplier, product code and date**. When you change supplier, get a full new set.

## 7. Selling a Finished Perfume

### The safety report (CPSR) and product file (PIF)

In the UK and EU, every cosmetic needs:

- a **CPSR (Cosmetic Product Safety Report)**, a safety assessment of the **whole finished product**, signed by a qualified safety assessor. You provide the full formula,

supplier documents, IFRA and allergen information, packaging details and stability data.

- a **PIF (Product Information File)**, the complete dossier for the product, including the CPSR and manufacturing information. It must be kept for **10 years** after the last batch is placed on the market.

**An IFRA certificate does not replace a CPSR.**

## Great Britain (UK)

- A **Responsible Person** with a UK address (this can be you).
- **Notify** the product through the government's **SCPN** service before selling.
- A CPSR and a PIF.
- Good manufacturing practice.
- A **label** showing: the Responsible Person's name and address, the quantity (e.g. 50 ml), the batch number, any warnings, the ingredient list (including allergens above the threshold) and, where needed, a durability date or period-after-opening symbol.

Guide: [GOV.UK — Making cosmetic products available to consumers in Great Britain](#)

## European Union

- A Responsible Person **based in the EU**. UK brands usually use an EU Responsible Person service.
- **Notify** the product through the EU's **CPNP** portal.
- A CPSR, a PIF, good manufacturing practice and a label, in the language of each country where you sell.
- Selling in both the UK and EU means **two** Responsible Persons and **two** notifications.

Guide: [European Commission — Cosmetics](#)

## United States

The US works differently. Under **MoCRA** (the 2022 cosmetics law), businesses generally have to:

- register facilities and list products with the FDA (some small businesses are exempt);
- keep evidence that products are safe;
- report serious adverse reactions;
- put contact details on the label.

At the time of writing, FDA rules on fragrance allergen labelling had not yet been published. Individual states may have extra rules. IFRA is not US law, but it is widely used.

Guide: [FDA — MoCRA](#)

## 8. Shipping Perfume

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Alcohol-based perfume is **flammable**. For shipping, it is classed as a **dangerous good**, typically **UN 1266, Perfumery products with flammable solvents, Class 3**. Road, air, sea and post each have their own rules on packaging, labelling, quantity limits and paperwork. Air is the strictest.

### IMPORTANT

Always follow dangerous-goods rules and your carrier's requirements. Never declare perfume as non-hazardous. It's illegal and a genuine fire risk. If you're unsure, ask your carrier's dangerous-goods team.

## 9. The Most Common Mistakes

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1. **Comparing concentrate % with the IFRA limit.** Always convert to the finished-product % first.
2. **Forgetting dilutions.** 5% of a 10% dilution is only 0.5% active.
3. **Using old IFRA certificates.** Check the Amendment number.
4. **Searching only by CAS number.** Also search by name and synonyms.
5. **Thinking "natural" means unrestricted.** Many restricted chemicals come from essential oils.
6. **Confusing allergens with IFRA limits.** They are separate rules.
7. **Treating an SDS or IFRA certificate as a safety report.** Neither replaces a CPSR.
8. **Treating supplier suggestions as legal limits.** Use the IFRA Standard and the law.
9. **Reading "parts" as percentages.** Convert:  $\text{parts} \div \text{total parts} \times 100$ .
10. **Measuring by volume.** Weigh everything.
11. **Formulating right at the limit.** Leave a margin.
12. **Assuming UK/EU rules apply everywhere.** Research your own country's laws.

## 10. Step-by-Step Workflow

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1. **Collect documents** for every raw material: SDS, IFRA certificate, allergen declaration, specification and COA.
2. **Record** each material's name, supplier, CAS number and dilution.
3. **Build your formula by weight** and convert it to percentages that add up to 100%.
4. **Work out active %** for any diluted materials.
5. **Find the restricted materials**, including chemicals inside naturals.
6. **Check the current IFRA Standards** for each one.
7. **Calculate the maximum dosage** and find your limiting material.

8. **Calculate allergens** in the finished product.
  9. **Prepare your fragrance documents** (IFRA certificate and allergen declaration).
  10. **Send everything to your safety assessor** or Responsible Person.
  11. **Complete the legal steps:** CPSR, PIF, notification and label.
  12. **Re-check** whenever your formula, supplier, the IFRA Standards or the law changes.
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## 11. Useful Links

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| Link                                             | Use it for                                     |
|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <a href="#">IFRA Standards Library</a>           | Looking up the real limit for any material.    |
| <a href="#">IFRA Standards documentation</a>     | IFRA's guidance, including product categories. |
| <a href="#">GOV.UK cosmetics guidance</a>        | UK rules for selling cosmetics.                |
| <a href="#">SCPN service</a>                     | Notifying products in Great Britain.           |
| <a href="#">European Commission — Cosmetics</a>  | EU rules and guidance.                         |
| <a href="#">EU CPNP</a>                          | Notifying products in the EU.                  |
| <a href="#">EU allergen regulation 2023/1545</a> | The official expanded allergen list and dates. |
| <a href="#">FDA — MoCRA</a>                      | US cosmetic requirements.                      |
| <a href="#">Health Canada — Cosmetics</a>        | Canadian cosmetic rules.                       |
| <b>Your own country's cosmetics regulator</b>    | The laws where you live and sell.              |

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# Perfumery Compliance Cheat Sheet

The key points on one page.

## Key formulas (all % by WEIGHT)

|                |                                                         |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| FINISHED %     | = material % in concentrate × dosage % ÷ 100            |
| MAX IN CONC. % | = IFRA limit × 100 ÷ dosage %                           |
| MAX DOSAGE %   | = IFRA limit ÷ material % in concentrate × 100          |
| ACTIVE %       | = formula % × dilution % ÷ 100                          |
| LIMITING       | = the lowest max dosage across all restricted materials |

### Category 4

- Category 4 is **fine fragrance**.
- Limits are **% of the finished perfume**.
- Other products have other limits.

### Allergens (UK/EU)

- Label if the finished product has > **0.001%** (leave-on) or > **0.01%** (rinse-off).
- EU expanded list from **31 July 2026**; GB: check OPSS.

### Documents for every material

SDS · IFRA certificate · Allergen declaration · Specification · COA

### To sell (UK/EU)

Responsible Person · CPSR · PIF · GMP · Notification (SCPN / CPNP) · Legal label

### Remember

- IFRA certificate ≠ safety report.
- Natural ≠ unrestricted.
- Weigh, don't measure.
- Keep a safety margin.
- Check the current IFRA Amendment.
- **Research your own country's and local laws.**

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*Written September 2026.*